

Het Icon Veneration

het-icon-veneration

Heterodoxy Marker · Eastern Orthodoxy · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

score 1.000
confidence medium

Statement under examination

The honor due to God alone is not to be rendered to images of Christ, of saints, or of the cross; saints are not to be petitioned in prayer as mediators of access to God.

In plain language

The proposition has two parts. First, the honor owed to God should not be given to images of Christ, of saints, or of the cross. Second, saints should not be asked in prayer to serve as mediators of access to God. The clearest lexical evidence is the Ten Commandments. The Hebrew forbids making a pesel, a carved cult image, and any temunah, a likeness, and then forbids bowing to them, the verb shachah, and serving them, the verb abad. Deuteronomy 4:15 grounds the rule in a perceptual fact: at Horeb you saw no form, so do not make any. Isaiah 44:17 names exactly the propositions two halves when it condemns the idol-maker who bows, worships, and prays to a pesel, three verbs stacked. In the New Testament, Jesus quotes Deuteronomy at Matthew 4:10 with two verbs and an adverb, you shall worship the Lord and serve him alone. The first verb is proskuneo and the second is latreuo, and the adverb monoi, alone, binds both to God. Two scenes show a created being refusing prostration: Peter raises Cornelius saying he too is only a man, and the angel forbids John and commands him to worship God. First Timothy 2:5 says there is one mediator, the man Christ Jesus. All of this leans toward the proposition. The reason the verdict is marked disputed is that the lexicon does not by itself rank every kind of relative honor. The Greek word proskuneo is used of creatures without condemnation, by the magi at Matthew 2:11, by the dying Jacob in Hebrews 11:21, and by the parable servant in Matthew 18:26. Hebrew shachah likewise covers Abrahams social bow in Genesis 23:7. The narrow cultic verb the canon does reserve for God is latreuo, with its noun latreia, and the Decalogues paired verb abad. So the words distinguish reserved cultic service from broader prostration, but they do not by themselves decide whether a non-cultic relative honor toward an image of Christ falls under forbidden prostration or under permitted creaturely homage. Cherubim were made by divine command without bowing attached, and the bronze serpent was a sight-object until incense was offered to it and it was destroyed.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H3742	כְּרוּב	keruv	cherub	
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	4,825
H5175	נָחָשׁ	nachash	serpent	
H5178	נְחֹשֶׁת	nechoshet	bronze	
H5180	נְחֹשְׁטָן	nechushtan	Nehushtan	
H5456	סָגַד	sagad	to prostrate	4
H5647	עָבַד	abad	to serve	290
H6419	פָּלַל	palal	to pray	84

H6459	לִפְסֵל	pesel	idol	31
H7812	שָׁחָה	shachah	to bow	163
H8544	תְּמוּנָה	temunah	likeness	10
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthropos	a human	567
G0846	αὐτός	autos	it/s/he	
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	367
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G2999	λατρεία	latreia	ministry	5
G3000	λατρεύω	latreuo	to minister	21
G3316	μεσίτης	mesites	mediator	6
G3441	μόνος	monos	alone	113
G4098	πίπτω	pipto	to collapse	90
G4352	προσκυνέω	proskuneo	to worship	60

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical core leans toward the proposition. The Decalogue forbids making a pesel or temunah and forbids bowing, shachah hishtaphel, and serving, abad, such objects. Deut 4:15 grounds that prohibition explicitly in the absence of any seen temunah at Horeb, and Isa 44:17 records the parallel idolatry triple sagad and shachah and palal, bowing and worshiping and praying to a pesel, which exactly mirrors the two halves of the proposition. Matt 4:10 quotes Deut 6:13 with two verbs and an adverb, kurion ton theon sou proskyneseis kai auto mono latreuseis, restricting both proskuneo and latreuo to God alone. Two NT prostration refusals, Acts 10:25-26 and Rev 22:8-9, show a created recipient refusing proskynesis and redirecting it to God. 1 Tim 2:5 fixes a single mesites. The proposition is nonetheless marked disputed because proskuneo is documented across the canon for non-divine prostration (Matt 18:26, Heb 11:21, the magi at Matt 2:11) and shachah likewise spans civil and cultic bowing (Gen 23:7), so the lexicon distinguishes the two cultic verbs latreuo and abad from the broader gesture verbs but does not by itself fix whether a non-cultic relative honor toward a Christian image of Christ or a saint falls under the prohibited acts or under permitted creaturely homage.

Scripture

Exod.20.4 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H6459 לִפְסֵל; H8544 תְּמוּנָה; H3808 אֵל

Force. The clause prohibits making a pesel, a carved cult image, together with any temunah, any likeness of what is in the heavens above, on the earth beneath, or in the waters below. The negation lo with the verb of making frames the object class broadly as fabricated cult representation.

Exod.20.5 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7812 שָׁחָה; H5647 עָבַד; H3808 אֵל

Force. Two negated verbs target the cultic response to such images: lo tishtachaveh, you shall not bow down or prostrate yourself, the hishtaphel of shachah, and lo taobdem, you shall not serve them, abad. The prohibition is on the directed act of prostration and service, not on the fabrication of an object as such.

Deut.5.8 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H6459 פסל; H8544 תמונה; H3808 אל

Force. The Deuteronomic restatement repeats pesel and temunah verbatim with the same negation, a restatement pattern that confirms the prohibition across the law section rather than confining it to one pericope.

Deut.5.9 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7812 שחה; H5647 עבד.

Force. The parallel to Exod 20:5, again pairing lo tishtachaveh with lo taobdem, confirms that bowing and serving toward the image are the prohibited cultic acts.

Deut.4.15 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H8544 תמונה; H3808 אל

Force. Moses grounds the prohibition in a perceptual fact: ki lo reitem kol temunah, for you saw no form, on the day Yahweh spoke from the midst of the fire at Horeb. The verse motivates the next verses verb pen tashchitun, lest you act corruptly and make for yourselves a pesel, temunat kol semel, a carved likeness of any figure. The grammar ties the no image rule to the absence of any seen divine form, not to a mere ban on craft.

Isa.44.17 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H5456 גדגד, H7812 שחה; H6419 פלל; H6459 פסל;

Force. The prophet describes the idol-maker who takes the remainder of his wood and makes a pesel of it, then yisgad lo veyishtachu veyitpalel elav, bows to it and worships it and prays to it. Three verbs stack: sagad bowing, shachah worshiping, palal praying or petitioning. The vocabulary maps directly onto the propositions two halves, prostration before an image and addressing it in petitionary prayer, and condemns the combination.

Matt.4.10 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4352 προσκυνέω, G3000 λατρεύω, G3441 μόνος, G2316 θεός

Force. Jesus answers Satan citing Deut 6:13 LXX in expanded form: kurion ton theon sou proskyneseis kai auto mono latreuseis, you shall worship the Lord your God and him alone shall you serve. Two future indicatives, proskyneseis and latreuseis, are governed by the adverb monoi, alone. The clause is the cleanest NT statement that the cultic gesture proskuneo plus cultic service latreuo are jointly reserved to God, with the adverb foreclosing extension to any other recipient.

1Tim.2.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G3316 μεσίτης, G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G2316 θεός

Force. heis gar theos, heis kai mesites theou kai anthropon, anthropos Christos Iesous, one God and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus. The numeral heis is predicative and exclusive over the noun mesites, framing a single channel of mediated access. The noun mesites occurs only six times in the canon and elsewhere is applied to Christ or to Moses as covenant mediator, never to a departed believer.

Acts.10.25 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4098 πίπτω, G4352 προσκυνέω

Force. Cornelius, having fallen, peson, at Peter's feet, prosekunesen, prostrated himself toward him. The scene records proskynesis directed at a created human recipient.

Acts.10.26 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0846 αὐτός, G0444 ἄνθρωπος

Force. Peter raises him with anastethi and the explanatory kai ego autos anthropos eimi, I myself am also a man. The created recipient refuses the directed prostration on the ground of his own creatureliness, redirecting honor away from himself.

Rev.22.8 · **for** · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G4098 πίπτω, G4352 προσκυνέω

Force. epesa proskunesai emprosthen ton podon tou angelou, John fell to prostrate himself before the feet of the angel who was showing him these things. Again proskynesis is directed at a created being.

Rev.22.9 · **for** · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G4352 προσκυνέω, G2316 θεός

Force. The angel forbids it with hora me, see that you do not, names himself syndoulos, a fellow servant, and commands to theo proskuneson, worship God. The creaturely recipient refuses proskynesis and redirects it to God alone, a refusal pattern parallel to Acts 10:26 and a near verbatim doublet of Rev 19:10.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Deut.5.8	Deut.4.15	tsk	1
Deut.5.9	Exod.20.4	tsk	1
Exod.20.5	Exod.34.14	tsk	1
Exod.20.5	Exod.23.24	tsk	1
Exod.20.4	Exod.32.1	tsk	1
1Tim.2.5	Job.9.33	tsk	1
Rev.22.9	Rev.19.10	tsk	1
Rev.22.9	Rev.4.10	tsk	1
Acts.10.25	Acts.14.11	tsk	1
Acts.10.26	Acts.14.14	tsk	1
Matt.4.10	Deut.6.13	tsk	1
Isa.44.17	Hab.2.18	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Matt.18.26 · **addressed**

The parable servant prostrates, prosekunei, before the king and the act is not condemned, showing that proskuneo by itself denotes prostration that can be either divine worship or non-divine homage. This is resolved by noting that Matt 4:10 pairs proskuneo with latreuo and the adverb mono so that the lexical reservation to God runs through the combination of cultic verbs plus adverb, and that the Decalogue attaches its prohibition to the cultic pesel plus serving abad, not to the bare gesture proskuneo or shachah in isolation.

Heb.11.21 · **addressed**

Jacob proskuneo upon the head of his staff, citing Gen 47:31. The verb describes the dying patriarchs reverent posture toward God, but the directional object is ambiguous between worship of God and a gesture made toward the staff as orienting object. This reinforces that proskuneo lexically does not by itself fix the recipient as God or as a creature, which is part of why the line drawn by the proposition is contested rather than lexically self-evident.

Gen.23.7 · **addressed**

Abraham bows, shachah hishtaphel, to the sons of Heth in a social courtesy that is not idolatry, demonstrating that shachah spans cultic and civil prostration. This is resolved by observing that the Decalogue qualifies the prohibited bowing by its object, a pesel made as a cult image, and pairs it with the cultic verb abad, so the verdict turns on the object class and on whether the act is cultic service rather than on the verb in isolation.

Matt.2.11 · addressed

The magi prosekunesan the child with the bringing of gifts, an act that within the narrative is treated approvingly. Whether this is read as recognition of incarnate deity or as royal homage at a birth, the lexical observation is the same: proskuneo by itself does not encode the latria reservation, which is carried in this Gospel by the Matt 4:10 pairing with latreuo and mono.

1Tim.2.1 · addressed

The immediate context urges intercessions, enteuxeis, made by living believers for one another, which shows that intercessory prayer among creatures exists. This is resolved against the petitioning of departed saints as mediators of access because 2:5 restricts the office of mesites, mediator of access to God, to the one man Christ Jesus, distinct from mutual intercession among the living.

Exod.25.18 · addressed

The kapporeth bears two keruvim of beaten gold by divine command at Exod 25:18-20. The verbs that attach to the cherubim are sokak, covering with their wings, and asah, making, not shachah, bowing, or abad, serving. The canon thus permits crafted images in cultic space when no bowing or service is directed at them, which is why the Decalogue prohibition is read as targeting directed cultic acts rather than craftsmanship as such. This is part of the lexical reason the doctrines scope is contested.

Num.21.8 · addressed

The bronze serpent, nachash nechosheth, is made by divine command and lifted on a pole. The verb that attaches to the people is nabat, to look, at Num 21:9, not shachah to bow. The image is a sight-object for healing, not a bow-object. 2 Kgs 18:4 records that when later Israelites began burning incense to it, qittarim, it became Nehushtan and was crushed, kittath, by Hezekiah. The same item that was permitted as a look-object was destroyed once the cultic verbs attached. The shift from nabat to incense is the lexical hinge: legitimacy of the image flipped exactly when prohibited cultic acts began to be directed at it.

Matt.4.10 · addressed

Jesus answer to Satan is itself the lexical disambiguator: by pairing proskuneo with latreuo and binding both with the adverb monos, the dominical citation of Deut 6:13 ranks the two verbs together as joint-reserved to God. Latreuo and its noun latreia, occurring 21 and 5 times respectively, are reserved across Hebrews, Romans, Acts, Luke, Matthew and Revelation for cultic service to God, never for honor to a creature. So the canon does mark a distinction between cultic worship-service that is reserved to God and prostration gestures that can be directed to creatures in non-cultic contexts, which gives the latria distinction a real lexical foothold even though it does not by itself license image-veneration.

Concordance traversed

H6459, H8544, H7812, H5647, H5456, H6419, H3808, H5175, H5178A, H5180, H3742, G4352, G3000, G2999, G3441, G4098, G1520, G3316, G0444, G2316

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope true and supplies no variant units for the cited verses. The Decalogue anchors are OT Hebrew outside CBGM scope, and the cited NT verses lie outside the 3 John CBGM sample, so no published ECM apparatus was examined. The verdict does not depend on any disputed reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. latria_dulia_distinction, covenant_theology, regulative_principle_of_worship

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

latría_dulia_distinction: disputed · This reading distinguishes worship, latría, the cultic act of latreuó and its noun latreía, which the canon reserves to God by joint pairing in Matt 4:10 with the adverb mono, from a lesser honor, dulia or relative veneration, directed through an image to its prototype. It observes that proskuneo and shachah both span cultic and non-cultic uses, that Heb 11:21 and Matt 18:26 and Matt 2:11 use proskuneo of creatures without condemnation, and that the canon does have legitimate image-craft in worship space such as the kapporeth keruvim and the bronze serpent before it became Nehushtan. On that lexical basis it treats the proposition as not lexically established because the line between cultic worship reserved to God and a permitted relative honor cannot be drawn from proskuneo alone. The strongest form of this lens grants that the law forbids cultic prostration plus service to a pesel and grants that Rev 22 and Acts 10 condemn prostration that crosses into latría, but holds that an image of Christ or a saint can carry an honor that is not latría and therefore is not within the forbidden class.

plain_sense_decatalogue: affirms · This reading takes the negated pesel and temunah together with the paired prohibition on bowing, shachah, and serving, abad, as a single prohibition on directing cultic prostration toward any fabricated likeness. Deut 4:15 grounds the law in the absence of any seen temunah of God, and Isa 44:17 condemns the triple sagad shachah palal, bowing worshiping praying, addressed to a pesel, mirroring the propositions two halves directly. The refusal pattern in Acts 10:26 and Rev 22:9, in which a created recipient says I am a fellow servant, worship God, and the dominical answer at Matt 4:10 with proskuneo and latreuó bound by mono, are read as drawing the line in the same place: the directed cultic act, by whatever verb, belongs to God alone, and a relative veneration that involves bowing or petitionary prayer to a created representation collapses into the forbidden class.

The verdict turns on whether the Greek noun latreía and the verb latreuó carve out a narrow class of acts reserved to God that does not include image-directed proskuneo when offered as relative honor, or whether the directed cultic act is forbidden under any verb when the recipient is a created representation. The lexicon distinguishes latreuó as the more strictly cultic of the two main NT verbs, but it does not rank a non-cultic image-directed proskuneo as either permitted or forbidden, which is the lexical seam the two lenses pull on. The Decalogue verbs shachah and abad also span semantic ranges, and Deut 4:15 grounds the no-image rule in absence of seen temunah rather than in a general ban on craft.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the canon's lexical pattern distinguishes honor or prostration that may be directed toward images of Christ, saints, or the cross, and whether departed saints may be addressed in prayer as mediators of access to God.

The original stem embeds a verdict by asserting that honoring images is rendering the honor due to God alone and by asserting that saints are not to be petitioned. The neutralized form poses the same lexical question without presupposing the answer. The verdict was derived on the original stem.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.20.4
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.20.5
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.5.8
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.4.15
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.44.17
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Num.21.8
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Kgs.18.4
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6459

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7812
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5456
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6419
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4352
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3000
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2999
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3316
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.4.10
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.10.26
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.22.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.2.5
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Exod.20.5
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.4.10
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rev.22.9
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Isa.44.17

License audit

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OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent